

Abraham Maslow's Vision for a Psychology of the Peace Table

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Version 1.01

For those of you who don't know, psychologist [Abraham Maslow](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Abraham_Maslow)¹ was an intellectual and theoretical giant, right up there at the top. He was the founding contributor of not one but two powerful new branches of Western Psychology, [Humanistic Psychology](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Humanistic_Psychology)² and [Transpersonal Psychology](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Transpersonal_Psychology).³

And that's just on the surface.

Underneath, he helped put into place theoretical and empirical foundations that he hoped would provide the path forward to a third new psychology, and advanced Utopian psychology, a [Eupsychian Psychology](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychian_Psychology),⁴ aimed at creating the "good society", a society capable of creating happy, healthy, autonomous, and advanced human beings. A society capable of actuating full [Human Potential](#) and engaging full [Human Flourishing](#).

Surprising?

Not really. Maslow wasn't the first scholar to try and push the world in a Utopian direction. [August Comte](#), for example, evangelist of empirical verification and founding father of Sociology, set out an entirely new [Religion of Humanity](#), a **universal religion** which he hoped would bring unity and shared purpose to humanity (Comte, 1852). Like Comte's Religion of Humanity, Maslow's Eupsychian project is not just a weak tweak, it is a full on revolution, a [Comprehensive Framework](#) for a new, Eupsychian social order.

Ambitious?

Definitely. As he said, in order to solve the psychological questions he had, he had to "invent another approach to psychological problems.... This approach slowly became a general philosophy of psychology, of science in general, of religion, work, management, and now biology. As a matter of fact, it became a Weltanschauung" (Maslow, 1969b, p. 724). Theoretically, it was a completely new view of human nature and potential, one that incorporated the insights of the Freudian and Behavioural schools, but that went well beyond them. Socially, he was talking about building out an entirely new system of socialization. Psychologically, it was a cure for mental and emotional disease. Politically, it was a "one-

1 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Abraham_Maslow

2 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Humanistic_Psychology

3 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Transpersonal_Psychology

4 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychian_Psychology

world politics” rooted in the notion that no matter what our ethnicity, gender, or skin colour, we were all part of the species (Tiller, 2004, p. 732).

Visionary?

Absolutely! Maslow’s utopian aspirations started, as these things often do, with a vision, experienced while he was driving home. As he recalled:

One day just after Pearl Harbor, I was driving home and my car was stopped by a poor, pathetic parade. Boy Scouts and fat people and old uniforms and a flag and someone playing a flute off-key. As I watched, the tears began to run down my face. I felt we didn’t understand — not Hitler, nor the Germans, nor Stalin, nor the Communists. We didn’t understand any of them. I felt that if we could understand, then we could make progress. **I had a vision of a peace table**, with people sitting around it, talking about human nature and hatred and war and peace and brotherhood... That moment changed my whole life.” (As quoted in Hoffman 1999:148–49: emphasis added)

As Maslow himself admits, this visionary experience, this [Darzana](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Darzana),⁵ redirected his life and work, as these things often do. He went from talking about dominance, sex, and motivation in apes to setting down a theory of human needs that he knew would become the root of a groundbreaking [Eupsychian Psychology](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychian_Psychology) aimed at creating the conditions for the health and happiness of the entire human species (Maslow, 1961a). Not to put too fine a point on it, rather than contributing to the machinery of war, he committed himself to developing what he called a *Psychology for the Peace Table*, a psychology rooted not in pathology (Freudianism), control (Behaviourism), and adjustment to a highly toxic society (Maslow, 1961b), but in understanding the human so as to facilitate healing and full actualization of not only the individual self, but of the entire species.

Amazing?

Indeed he was. Maslow would spend his entire career attempting to build that psychology. His contributions, already intimated, were massive. He helped found the *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* in 1961 to serve as a platform for exploring these alternative, growth-oriented views of human nature (Bugental 1964). He helped found the *Journal of Transpersonal Psychology* in 1969, to explore the “Farthest Reaches of Human Nature” (Maslow, 1969a), i.e., the spiritual, mystical, and transcendent dimensions of the human experience. The culmination of these efforts was the nascent emergence of a [Eupsychian Psychology](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychian_Psychology),⁶ a psychology that would not only help resacralize an arid and dehumanized science (Maslow, 1966; Sutich, 1961, 1976), but would also specify exactly how to grow healthy, strong, whole, autonomous, fully functioning human beings. It would all be grounded in a [Eupsychian Theory](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychian_Theory) that would contribute, according to Maslow, to a reconceptualization of “every area of human knowledge: e.g., economics, sociology, biology, and every profession: e.g., the family, education,

5 <https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Darzana>

6 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychian_Psychology

religion, etc.” (Maslow 1970:x) and provide new systems of meaning where religion had so thoroughly failed (Maslow 1964)

What Else Can I Say?

Maslow’s contribution was stunning. In just a little over two decades he went from visionary experience to actual implementation. In 1969 he wrote that, “There is now available a new conception, of a higher possibility, of the healthy society. There are tools now available to judge and compare societies. One society can be judged to be better than another society, or healthier or possessing more ‘growth-fostering-potential.’ We can talk about the value of the society, or the function of the society—that is, the greatest coming to fulfillment of the people in the society” (Maslow, 1969a, p. 7).

It is worthwhile reviewing the preceding paragraph. Maslow felt he had accomplished what he set out to do, build a Psychology for the Peace table. Of course, he didn’t do it alone and he wasn’t anywhere near finished, but it was his vision from the start. He was also very clear that the work that he and others had done by 1970 was only the “bare beginning” (Maslow 1970:xxi); nevertheless progress had been made.

Tragically, Maslow’s vision was never fully realized. He died prematurely in 1970, at the age of 62. But more than that, as Elkins (2009) documents, the broader humanistic project that Maslow helped inaugurate was aggressively marginalized and systematically defunded. I am an eyewitness to this assassination. In the fourth year of my undergraduate psychology degree (circa 1985), all the humanistic, transpersonal, and existential psychologists in my small department were retired and replaced with behaviourists, cognitive-behaviourists and, later, the positive psychology offered by the establishment today.

Note, it is crucial to clarify that when I use the metaphor of “murder,” I am not alleging a secret, coordinated conspiracy in the cloak-and-dagger sense. Rather, as the evidence in Elkins’s article show, I am describing a socio-political and academic process of systematic marginalization that was public, multifaceted, and intentional. This process was driven by what Elkins called “destructive forces” (Elkins, 2009, p. 271) but what I would call an [Accumulating Class](#) intent on preserving their exploitative status quo. These forces operated not in shadowy secrecy, but through visible channels: the “virulent attack from right-wing and reactionary groups” that Carl Rogers documented as early as 1970 (as cited in Elkins, 2009, p. 273); the “negative stereotypes” perpetuated in mainstream journals (Elkins, 2009, p. 279); and the institutional “failing to acknowledge the scholarly contributions of humanistic psychology” by influential figures (Elkins, 2009, p. 280). The “death” of humanistic psychology’s influence was the result of this “coordinated campaign” of opposition (Elkins, 2009, p. 286), not a natural death due to inherent flaws. To understand this not as a conspiracy theory but as a documented historical conflict, one need only look to the “fundamental divide” and “radical conflict” between the assumptions of humanistic psychology and the “basic assumptions and values of contemporary mainstream psychology” (Elkins, 2009, p. 284) and capitalist society. The metaphor of

murder is used here to refute the notion of suicide and to correctly assign agency for this decline to these powerful, external actors.

Whatever the reason for Humanistic Psychology's decline, it was gone in an instant. Its emancipatory, truth-seeking, growth-affirming, revolutionary impulse effectively erased. It still exists, of course, and still has some influence (DeRobertis, 2013) but, I would argue in a castrated and caricatured (Sosteric, in press) form.

It is shocking when you think about it, particularly where you consider where we might be now, empirically and theoretically, if the humanistic world view had been properly supported to grow.

Oh well.

As the proverb goes, no sense crying over spilt milk. Was *geschehen ist, ist geschehen*. *Omi tó tán lóri ilè kò lè jònà* 覆水盆に返らず . *गया वक्त वापस नहीं आता*

The past is past.

It is a waste to spend too much energy there.

So... what are we going to do?

Well, we have to do something. The inadequacies of our existing philosophical, methodological, and ideological systems has never been clearer. The need for a Psychology of the Peace Table has never been more pressing. The world is facing a polycrisis (Albert, 2024). If we don't do something, things are going to keep getting worse.

Therefore, I propose we establish Maslow's Peace Table, right here, right now, initially [in this online space](#)⁷ but expanding as we go. Here we (scholars, writers, professionals) can start talking openly about the things we need to know, the things we need to do, and the things we need to make (new institutions, etc.) in order to create healthy, happy humans capable of manifesting Maslow's Eupsychia. We can root this in Maslow's seminal work (and the work of [Key Eupsychian Figures](#)⁸ like Comte, Fromm, Grof, Rogers, Horney, and May, etc.), but we can move beyond with our own empirical, theoretical, and even "mystical" insights (Sosteric, 2022), together building the new system that Maslow wanted to build and doing it with full, transformative intent.

We, and by "we" I mean the human species, are about to lose everything we've worked for.

We can't keep acting "normal."

What else are we going to do?

7 <https://medium.com/the-peace-table>

8 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychia_Key_Figures

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